Folk Models of Good and Bad Taste: A Computational Text Analysis

Omar Lizardo
Department of Sociology, UCLA

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Abstract

oindent Sociologists have long debated the nature of "good" and "bad" taste, yet how lay individuals actually define these categories remains under-explored. Using open-ended survey responses, this research note applies Non-Negative Matrix Factorization (NMF) to inductively map folk cultural models of taste definitions. I identify distinct cultural models for "good taste" (e.g., Similar Say Usually, Art Appreciate Quality, Look Appealing Clothing, Pleasing Choices Aesthetically) and "bad taste" (e.g., Likes Different Opinion, Choices Music Clothing, Usually Quality Ugly, Care Really Look). Chi-square cross-tabulations reveal that these cultural models form internally coherent cultural logics across both positive and negative evaluations. Furthermore, heatmaps mapping these cultural models onto 19 specific cultural domains reveal that while core domains like Music and Clothing are universally subjected to taste distinctions, specific aesthetic and subjective models are associated with varying propensities to draw taste boundaries across nearly all domains.

1 Introduction

The sociological study of cultural stratification has traditionally focused on how cultural consumption patterns map onto social hierarchies (Bourdieu, 1984). However, theoretical conceptualizations of “good” and “bad” taste are rarely compared against how everyday people implicitly define these constructs, although some recent interview-based work has begun to plumb this subject (Haak and Wilterdink, 2019; Jarness and Friedman, 2017). Do people view good taste as an aesthetic achievement, a moral disposition, or mere consensus with dominant trends? Better understanding these folk models of taste can provide vital insight into the contemporary boundaries of cultural inclusion and exclusion.

2 Research Questions

This research note is guided by three primary research questions:

1. What are the distinct, latent cultural models that lay individuals use to define “good taste” and “bad taste”?
2. How do cultural models of good taste relate to cultural models of bad taste? Are they structurally coupled into broader cultural logics?
3. How do these taste cultural models map onto specific cultural domains (e.g., beer, classical music, wrestling)?

3 Methods

To analyze these short, unstructured participant-level text responses (hereafter “documents”), I used **Non-Negative Matrix Factorization (NMF)**. During preprocessing, domain-specific survey artifacts (e.g., “good,” “bad,” “taste,” “don’t”) were removed from each document because these words—mostly paraphrasing the original question—were overwhelmingly common across documents and thus did little to differentiate them. We also remove common English stop words from each document (e.g., the, it, is, do, etc.). The algorithm was optimized for each of the two text fields independently to prevent vocabulary blurring. Finally, to explore the structural relationships between the documents and the derived topics, I conducted a Correspondence Analysis (CA). The CA was computed directly on the $N \times K$ soft-assignment matrix of document-to-topic probabilities generated by the NMF (with a minimal constant added to prevent division-by-zero errors), visualizing the geometric distance between respondents’ nuanced linguistic choices across the components.

3.1 Parameter Selection and Model Robustness

To ensure our topic solutions were empirically robust, we evaluated NMF models across a range of component configurations (K). The optimal configuration balances two competing demands: maximizing the granularity of semantic clusters while minimizing reconstruction error. We optimized for a 4-topic solution for both Good Taste and Bad Taste. This configuration prevents the model from collapsing into overly generic schemas while maintaining distinct qualitative variation.

4 Results

4.1 Cultural Models of Taste

For **Good Taste**, four primary cultural models emerged from the NMF analysis: *Similar Say Usually* (highlighting subjective similarity and opinion), *Art Appreciate Quality* (focusing on aesthetic appreciation of art and food), *Look Appealing Clothing* (emphasizing visual appeal and clothing choices), and *Pleasing Choices Aesthetically* (centering on aesthetic stylishness).

Topic	Count	Name	Representation
0	46	Similar Say Usually	similar, say, usually, likes, opinion, interests, certain...
1	99	Art Appreciate Quality	art, appreciate, quality, enjoy, food, way, style...
2	39	Look Appealing Clothing	look, appealing, clothing, way, knows, pick, listen...
3	40	Pleasing Choices Aesthetically	pleasing, choices, aesthetically, make, stylish, typically, ...

Table 1: Good Taste Def Summary

Topic	Name	Representative Document
0	Similar Say Usually	"I'd say a person has good taste if I like similar things."
1	Art Appreciate Quality	"What I mean by that is they have a taste similar to mine or one I can appreciate. People who enjoy the same type of books or movies or art. Though I can understand someone may have exceptional taste and I don't agree with it. Such as enjoying Rothko's art or Wharton's novels. "
2	Look Appealing Clothing	"Something that they like has an appealing look"
3	Pleasing Choices Aesthetically	"Their choices are aesthetically pleasing to me. "

Table 2: Representative Quotes for Good Taste Cultural Models

For **Bad Taste**, respondents defined it through four distinct cultural models: *Likes Different Opinion* (emphasizing subjective differences and disagreement), *Choices Music Clothing* (focusing on poor choices in specific domains like music and clothing), *Usually Quality Ugly* (centering on low quality or ugliness), and *Care Really Look* (highlighting gaudiness and lack of care in appearance).

4.2 Cross-Cultural Model Logics

To test whether these cultural models are isolated or form coherent "logics," I cross-tabulated respondents' primary cultural models across the two questions. The associations are statistically significant ($\chi^2 = 20.88, p < 0.05$). For instance, individuals who define good taste

Topic	Count	Name	Representation
0	62	Likes Different Opinion	likes, different, opinion, say, art, dislike, interests...
1	66	Choices Music Clothing	choices, music, clothing, preferences, shows, food, unappeal...
2	50	Usually Quality Ugly	usually, quality, ugly, poor, way, likes, looks...
3	46	Care Really Look	care, really, look, colors, items, gaudy, know...

Table 3: Bad Taste Def Summary

Topic	Name	Representative Document
0	Likes Different Opinion	"When I say that someone has bad taste, it means that in my opinion, the things that person likes is very different from the things I like, so, therefore, they have bad taste."
1	Choices Music Clothing	"Someone who has bad taste in clothing choices, music, food, dating preferences. "
2	Usually Quality Ugly	"Usually it is about gaining noteriety at the expense of quality. It is a the immature desire tp shock others in negative ways and usually means poor quality."
3	Care Really Look	"some just like anything really don't care "

Table 4: Representative Quotes for Bad Taste Cultural Models

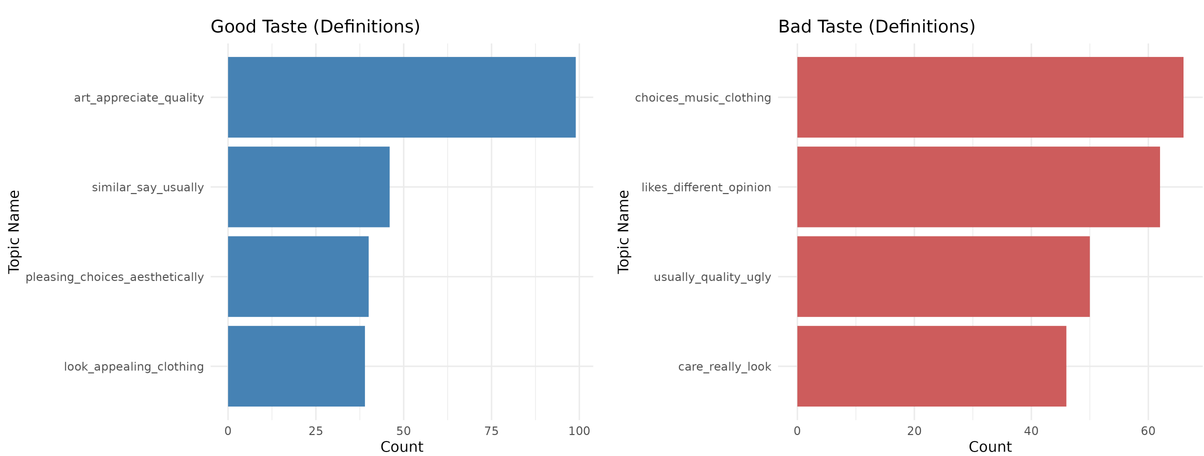


Figure 1: Topic Frequencies for Good and Bad Taste (Definitions)

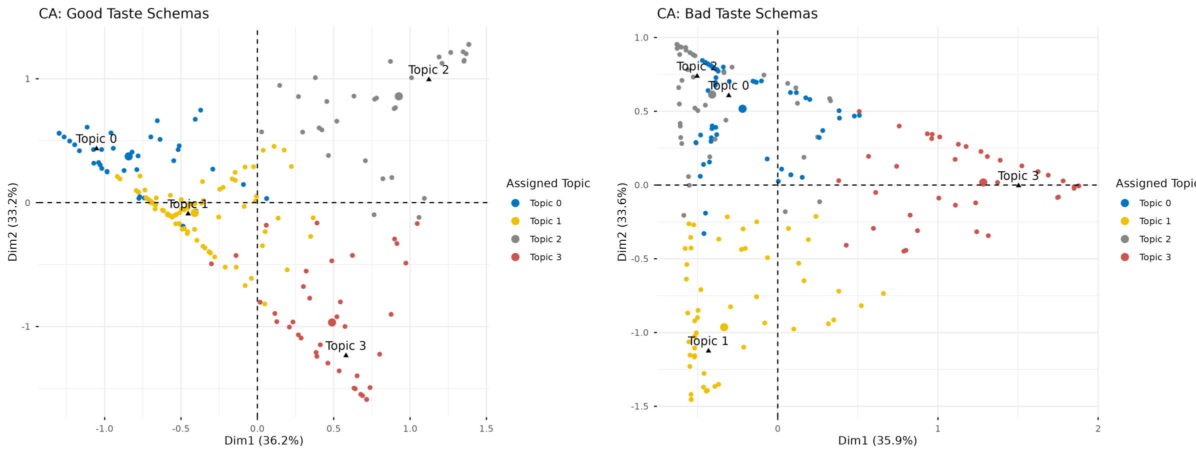
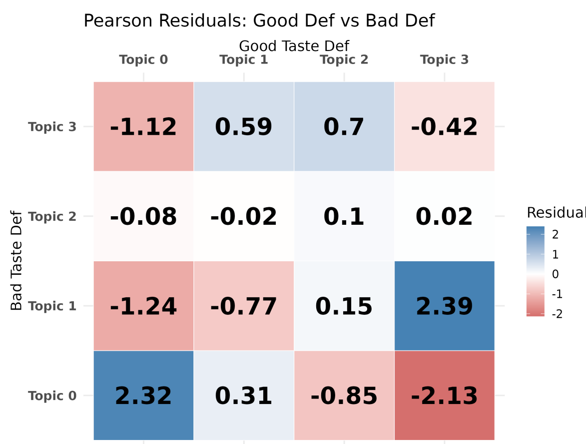


Figure 2: Correspondence Analysis of Taste Cultural Models (Definitions)

as subjective similarity (*Similar Say Usually*) strongly tend to define bad taste as subjective difference (*Likes Different Opinion*). Likewise, those focused on aesthetics (*Pleasing Choices Aesthetically*) often define bad taste through the lens of specific choices (*Choices Music Clothing*).



4.3 Demographics

To examine whether taste cultural models are patterned by socio-demographic factors, I fit multinomial logistic regression models predicting respondents' primary topic cultural model (across both models) using their Age, Gender, Education (factor), Parent's Education (factor), and Political Orientation (categorical: Liberal, Moderate, Conservative). The Likelihood Ratio χ^2 tests are presented below.

To further illustrate these significant demographic boundaries, I plotted the predicted marginal probabilities for respondents' primary schemas across the statistically significant demographic predictors across both models: Age, Gender, Education, and Parent's Education.

Model	Predictor	LR χ^2	Df	p-value
Good Taste Def	poly(Age, 2)	16.46	6	0.0115
Good Taste Def	Gender	15.65	3	0.0013
Good Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	38.16	12	¡ 0.001
Good Taste Def	ParentEducation_Coded	29.23	12	0.0036
Good Taste Def	Political	24.19	3	¡ 0.001
Bad Taste Def	poly(Age, 2)	14.96	6	0.0206
Bad Taste Def	Gender	8.05	3	0.0451
Bad Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	26.32	12	0.0097
Bad Taste Def	ParentEducation_Coded	21.14	12	0.0484
Bad Taste Def	Political	6.25	3	0.1001

Table 5: Multinomial Logistic Regression Likelihood Ratio Tests for Topic Predictors

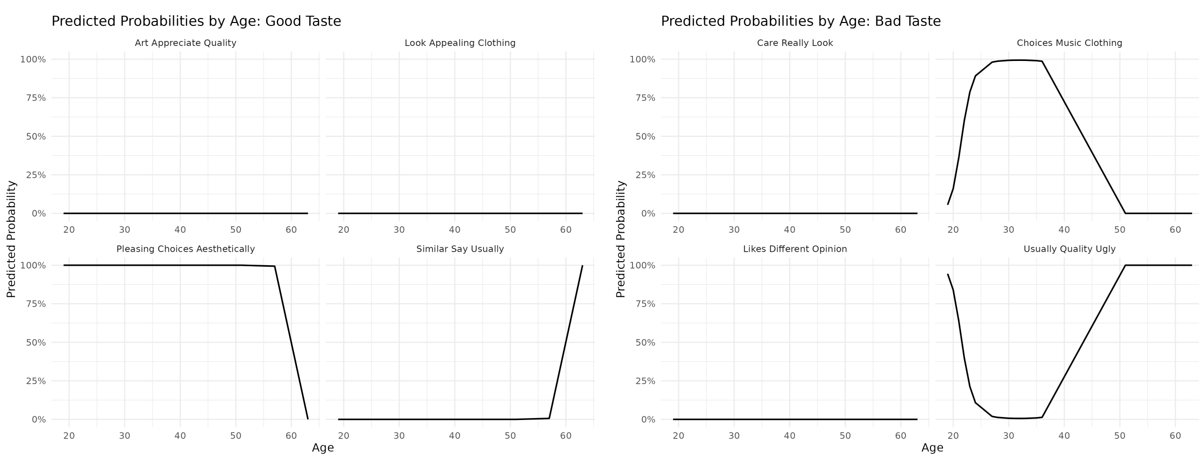


Figure 3: Predicted Probabilities of Cultural Models by Age

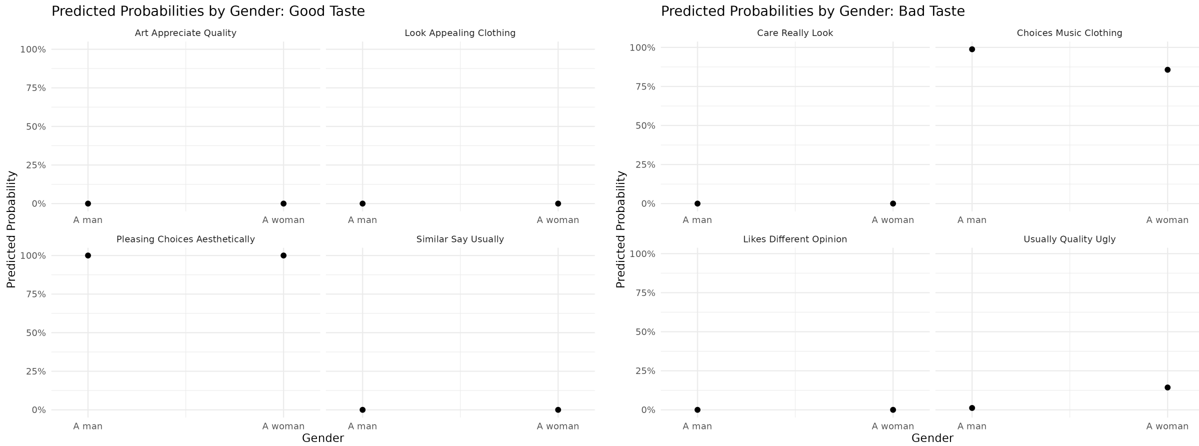


Figure 4: Predicted Probabilities of Cultural Models by Gender

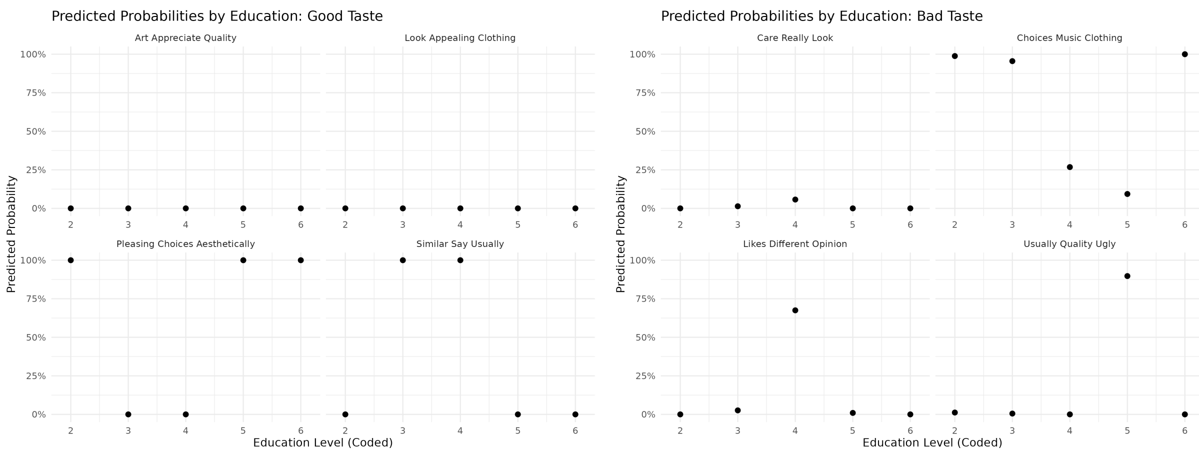


Figure 5: Predicted Probabilities of Cultural Models by Education Level

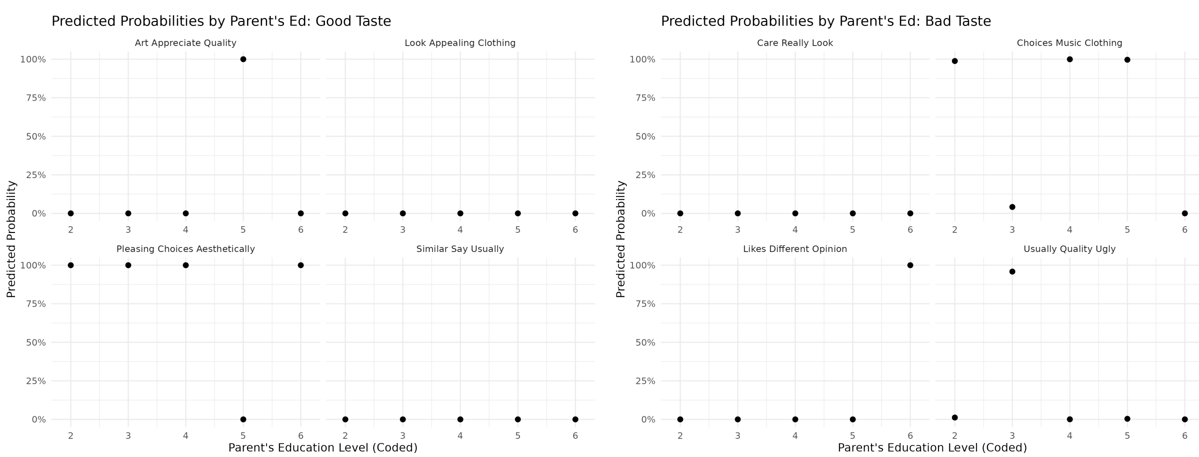


Figure 6: Predicted Probabilities of Cultural Models by Parent's Education Level

4.4 Domain Distinction PCA and ANOVA

To analyze respondents' propensity to draw cultural boundaries across domains without testing 19 individual domains simultaneously, I conducted a Principal Component Analysis (PCA) on the distinction ratings. I ran this for four different blocks of survey items: *Distinction 1*, *Distinction 2*, *Importance*, and *Knowledge*.

The first dimension captures a general propensity to draw distinctions across all domains (as all variables load positively). The subsequent dimensions capture domain-specific clusters (e.g., separating traditional high-brow arts from pop culture or recreational activities).

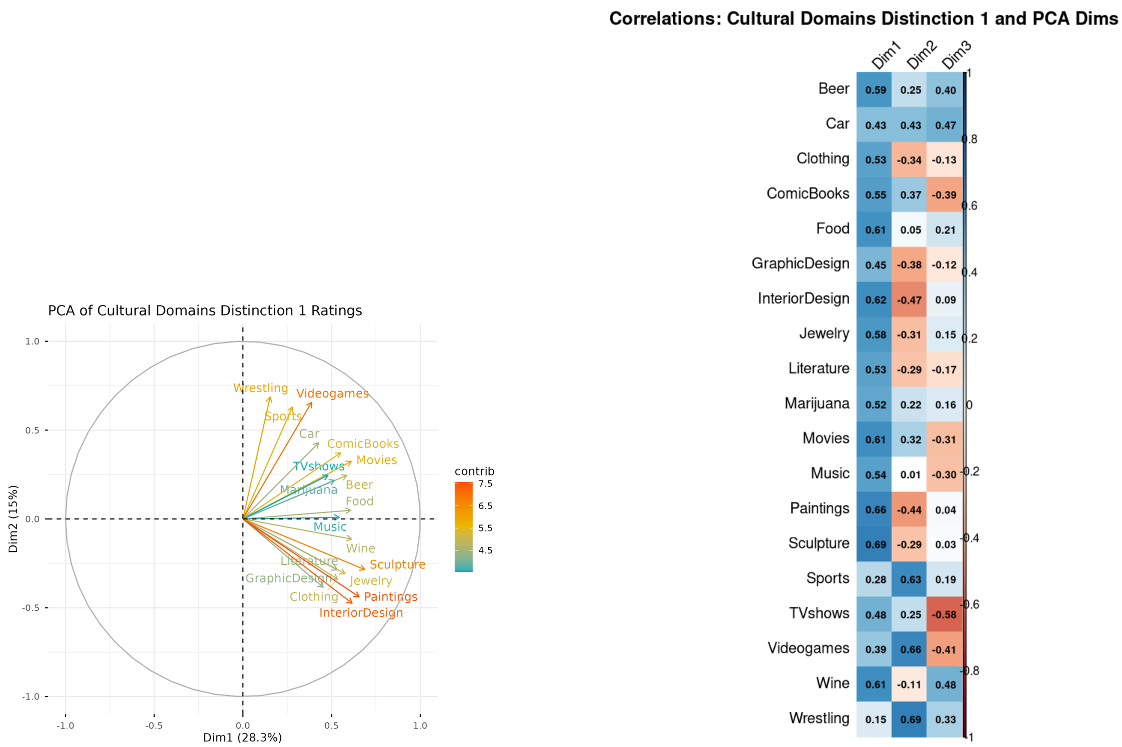


Figure 7: PCA and Correlations for Distinction 1

I extracted the individual respondent scores for the first three PCA dimensions for each block and ran a MANOVA (Pillai's trace) to test whether mean scores across the three dimensions differ significantly depending on the respondent's topic cultural model assignment. The results demonstrate how different cultural models of taste correspond to distinct configurations of cultural boundary-drawing.

4.5 Domain Distinction Heatmaps

Respondents were also asked to rate whether it "makes sense" to distinguish good and bad taste across 19 different domains (from -3 = Strongly Disagree to +3 = Strongly Agree).

Visualizing these scores as heatmaps across our topic clusters reveals several structural universals: regardless of the cultural model, respondents highly agree that taste distinctions make sense for **Clothing, Interior Design, Movies, Music, and Paintings**, while

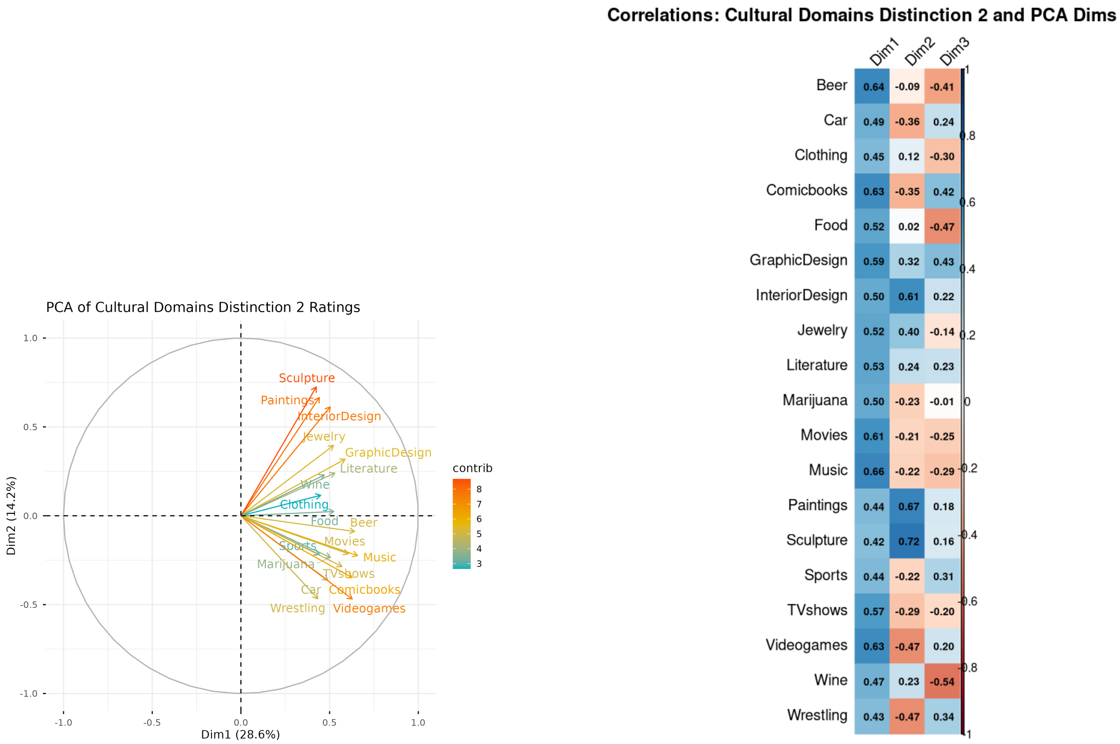


Figure 8: PCA and Correlations for Distinction 2

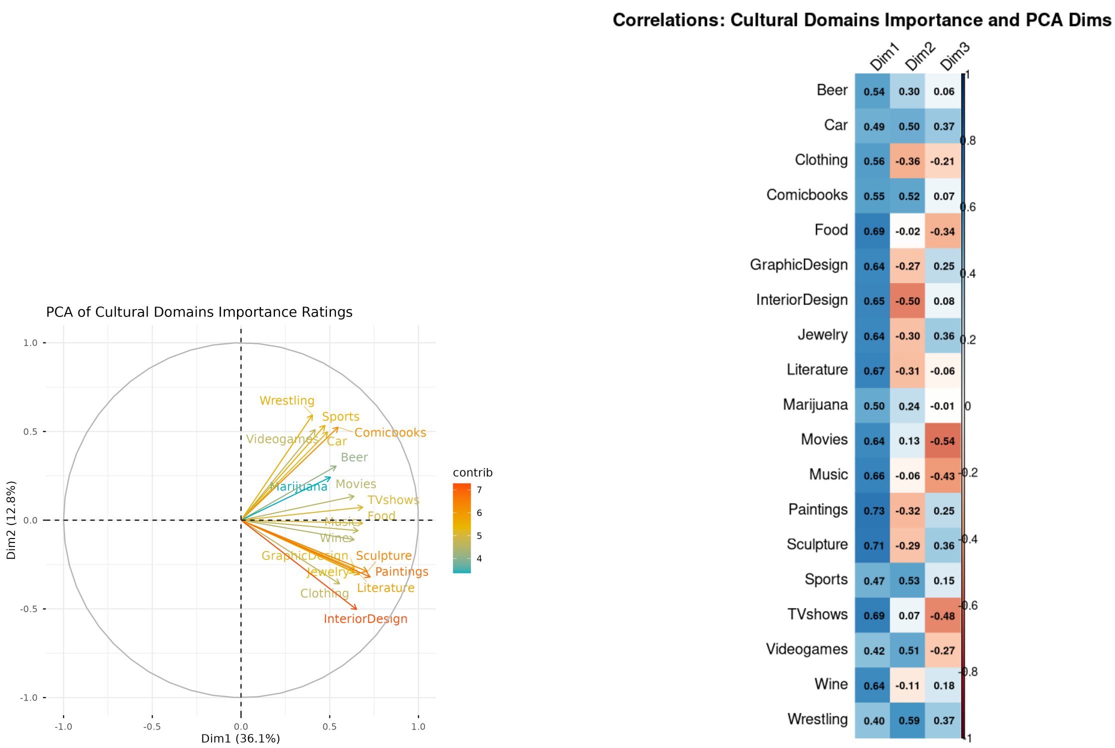


Figure 9: PCA and Correlations for Importance

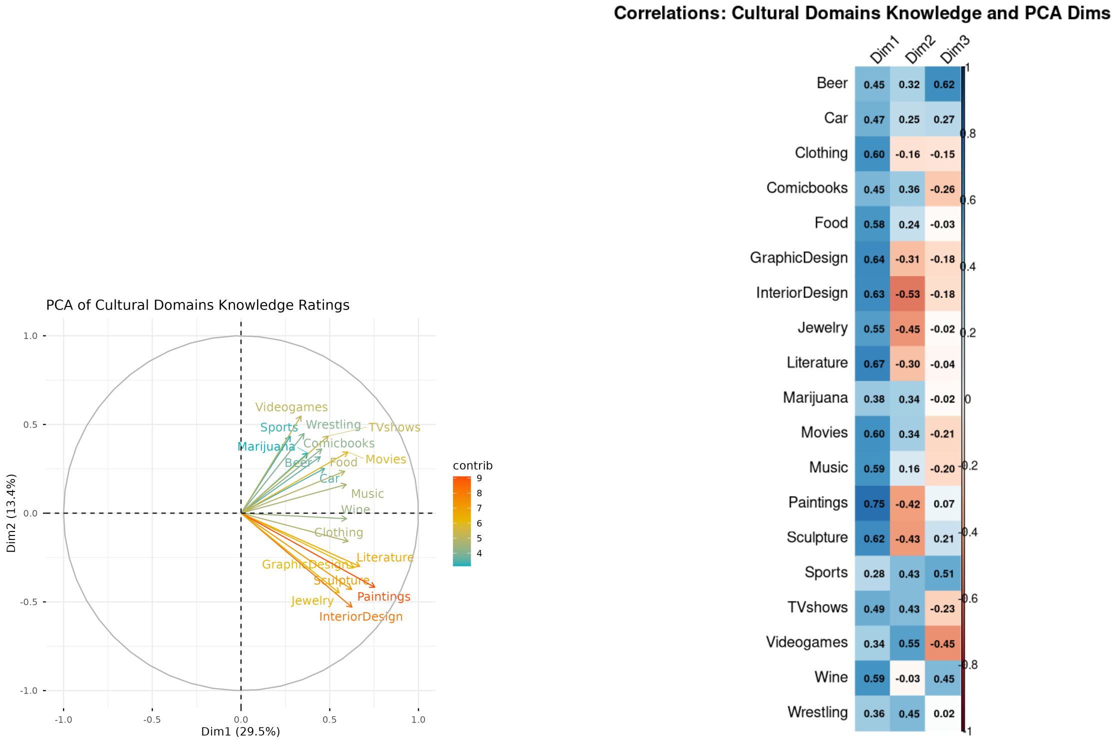


Figure 10: PCA and Correlations for Knowledge

Predictor	Pillai's Trace	approx F	num Df	den Df	p-value
Good Taste Def	0.055	1.26	9	609	0.258
Bad Taste Def	0.068	1.58	9	609	0.117

$^{*}p < 0.05; ^{**}p < 0.01; ^{***}p < 0.001$

Table 6: MANOVA Results: Differences in PCA Dimensions (1-3) of Cultural Domains Distinction 1 Ratings by Taste Cultural Model.

Predictor	Pillai's Trace	approx F	num Df	den Df	p-value
Good Taste Def	0.023	0.51	9	609	0.865
Bad Taste Def	0.048	1.09	9	609	0.365

$^{*}p < 0.05; ^{**}p < 0.01; ^{***}p < 0.001$

Table 7: MANOVA Results: Differences in PCA Dimensions (1-3) of Cultural Domains Distinction 2 Ratings by Taste Cultural Model.

Predictor	Pillai's Trace	approx F	num Df	den Df	p-value
Good Taste Def	0.030	0.68	9	609	0.730
Bad Taste Def	0.044	1.00	9	609	0.439

$^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$

Table 8: MANOVA Results: Differences in PCA Dimensions (1-3) of Cultural Domains Importance Ratings by Taste Cultural Model.

Predictor	Pillai's Trace	approx F	num Df	den Df	p-value
Good Taste Def	0.035	0.81	9	609	0.609
Bad Taste Def	0.039	0.90	9	609	0.524

$^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$

Table 9: MANOVA Results: Differences in PCA Dimensions (1-3) of Cultural Domains Knowledge Ratings by Taste Cultural Model.

rejecting taste distinctions for **Car Races and Wrestling**.

5 Discussion

This text-analytic exploration demonstrates that lay definitions of taste are not monolithic; they are multi-dimensional, spanning aesthetic, subjective, and quality-based dimensions. Crucially, these dimensions are symmetrical. If an individual views good taste through the lens of objective aesthetic criteria, they evaluate bad taste using the exact same yardstick.

Furthermore, by mapping these inductively derived cultural models back onto structured survey variables, we observe that the specific folk model an individual uses dictates the breadth of their cultural boundary-drawing. Future research should expand on these findings by examining how these deeply held, qualitative cultural models of taste interact with actual patterns of structural inequality.

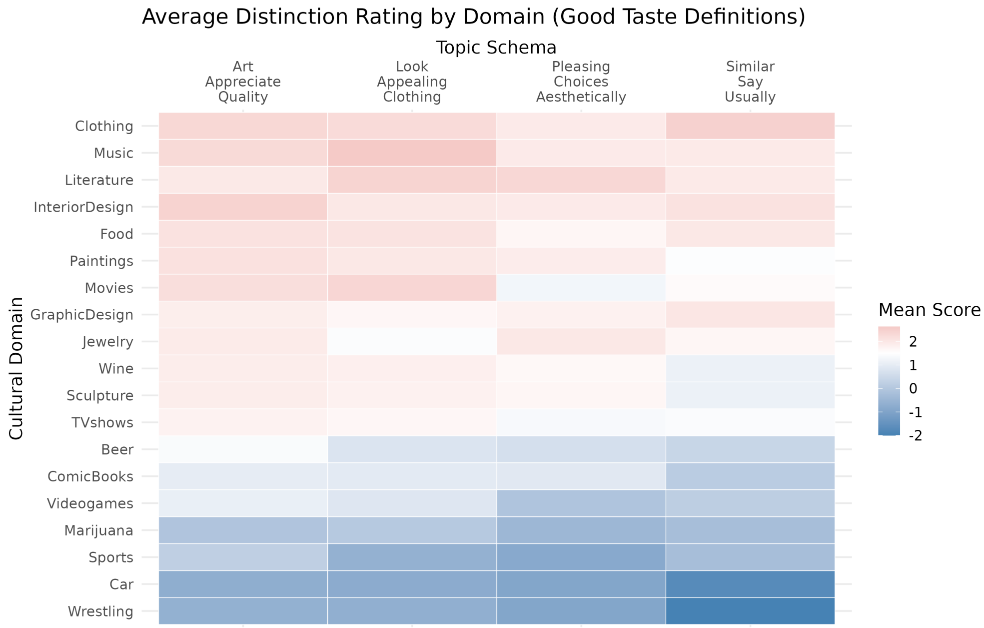


Figure 11: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Good Taste Cultural Model (Definitions)

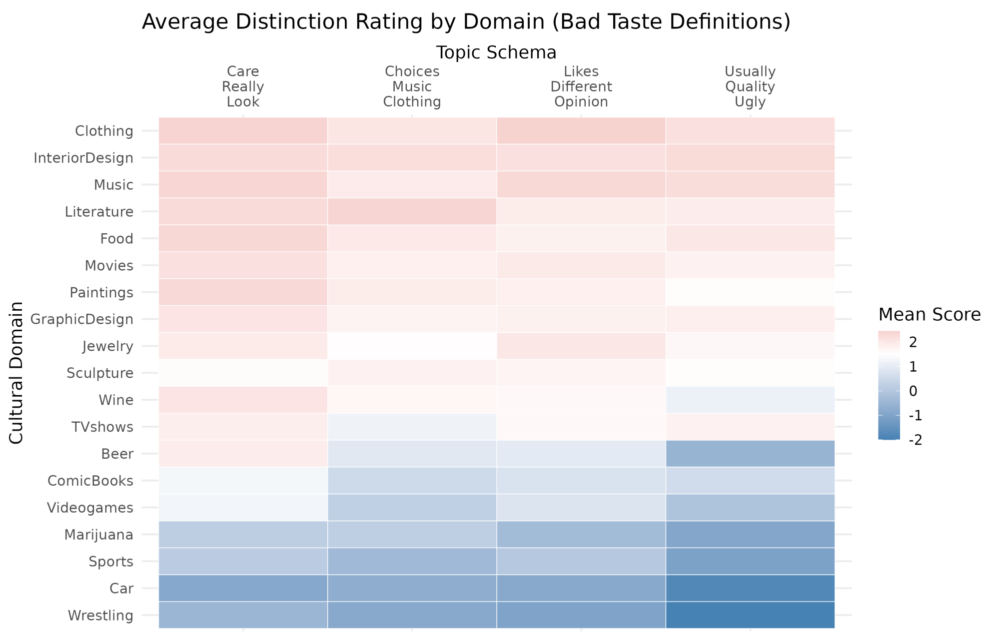


Figure 12: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Bad Taste Cultural Model (Definitions)

References

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Haak, M. v. d. and Wilterdink, N. (2019). Struggling with distinction: How and why people switch between cultural hierarchy and equality. *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 22(4):416–432.

Jarness, V. and Friedman, S. (2017). 'i'm not a snob, but...': Class boundaries and the downplaying of difference. *Poetics*, 61:14–25.